The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Saudi Aramco, an oil giant owned by the Saudi state, reported profits of $121bn in 2023, down from $161bn in 2022. Lower oil prices partly explain the fall. Even so, the profits were the firm's second-highest ever. The company said that last year it raised its dividends, a crucial source of income for the Saudi government, by 30% to $97.8bn.

Leo Varadkar, Ireland's prime minister, acknowledged defeat in a two-part **referendum** about modernising the constitution. His government had sought to expand the constitutional definition of families to include "durable relationships". And it wanted to change a reference to a mother's "duties in the home" to one about family-based care. Around 70% of voters rejected each proposal. Turnout was just over 44%.

President Joe Biden accused **Binyamin Netanyahu**, his Israeli counterpart, of "hurting Israel" with the mounting death toll in **Gaza**. But Mr Biden also reiterated that the "defence of Israel is still critical". Meanwhile, America's army dispatched a ship to Gaza carrying equipment to build a temporary pier off the enclave's coast. The pier would receive much-needed aid shipments but could take up to 60 days to build.

India signed a trade pact with the European Free Trade Association. India's trade minister said his country would waive most tariffs on industrial goods from Iceland, Liechtenstein, Norway and Switzerland. These countries have agreed to invest $100bn in India over 15 years. India has recently signed similar deals with Australia and the United Arab Emirates; it is reportedly in the late stages of negotiations with Britain.

Asif Ali Zardari was voted president of Pakistan by the country's parliamentarians. He was supported by the Pakistan Peoples Party and the Pakistan Muslim League-Nawaz, two parties that formed a coalition government after last month's controversial general election. Mr Zardari's term, which begins on Sunday, will be his second. His first, from 2008 to 2013, took place in the aftermath of the assassination of his wife, Benazir Bhutto, Pakistan's first female prime minister.

Cabin crew of **Lufthansa**, Germany's biggest airline, called a two-day strike for better pay. The action is scheduled to take place on Tuesday and Wednesday. Staff believe they should benefit more from the firm's recent bumper results. It earned record profits of €1.7bn ($1.8bn) in 2023. The strike, which follows one by ground staff last week, could affect 100,000 travellers.

Joe Biden signed a $460bn package of spending bills into law just in time to prevent a partial **government shutdown**. The six bills, which were passed by the Senate on Friday, fund various government departments, including housing and transport, until the end of September. The work is not yet done, though. The deadline for passing six more such bills, which include funding for defence, is March 22nd.

Word of the week: Hindutva, a belief in the hegemony of Hinduism in India, which originated in the anti-colonial movements of the 20th century. Read the full story.

In the run-up to America's presidential election, we've launched The US in brief—a daily update to help you keep on top of the political stories that matter. Sign up here to receive it as a newsletter, each weekday, in your inbox.

Photo: Getty Images

A testing Ramadan begins in Gaza

Ramadan begins at sundown on Sunday. But despite guarded optimism in the past few weeks about a break in the fighting in Gaza, the Muslim holy month may not bring that respite. America's president, Joe Biden, had hoped to announce a ceasefire in his state-of-the-union speech on Thursday. Instead he announced a plan to build a pier off Gaza's coast to receive shipments of humanitarian aid.

This will not immediately alleviate the growing hunger in Gaza. Even if work begins this weekend, it will take weeks for the pier to be ready. Meanwhile, Egyptian and Qatari brokers still hold out hope that talks in Cairo could yield a six-week truce and the release of Israeli hostages, now held in Gaza for over five months. But many issues remain unresolved, including that of Palestinian prisoners held by Israel and the positioning of Israeli troops in Gaza during a potential ceasefire.

Photo: AP

Portugal’s sensible election

A fallen prime minister, snap elections, a fragmented party system and an ascendant hard-right. It sounds like a formula for instability. Yet Portugal’s general election on Sunday will probably allow the traditional political parties to stay in power.

Antonio Costa headed a stable majority government until an influence-peddling scandal broke in November. He stepped down, denying wrongdoing, to fight the charges. The new prime minister will be either Mr Costa’s fellow Socialist, Pedro Nuno Santos, or Luis Montenegro of the centre-right Social Democrats.

Polls say Mr Montenegro may come first, though the left-wing parties taken together may do better than the right-leaning ones. The populist new-right Chega could double its vote from the last election in 2022. But other parties have promised not to work with it. The most likely scenario is a wobbly centrist government that the other side will reluctantly vote for to keep Chega out.

Photo: Getty Images

The Oscars go global

In 2020 “Parasite”, a South Korean film, became the first foreign-language feature to win the Academy Award for Best Picture, breaking what its director, Bong Joon-ho, called the “one-inch-tall barrier of subtitles”. Every year since, an international, foreign-language title has been nominated for the top prize. This year, for the first time, there are two: “Anatomy of a Fall” (France) and “The Zone of Interest” (Britain/Poland). “Past Lives”, an American production chiefly in Korean, is also on the shortlist. Another first: not one nominee in the documentary category is American.

The increasingly international character of the Oscars reflects the Academy’s efforts to become more diverse and global. In 2015 a hashtag, #OscarsSoWhite, drew attention to its predominantly white membership. The share of members from underrepresented races and ethnicities has since doubled. The body’s international membership has risen to around 20%. “Oppenheimer” is odds-on to win Best Picture. But whoever takes home Hollywood’s holy grail, international cinema has already won.

Photo: © Sudhir Dasgupta

The growing popularity of South Asian music

This weekend the Southbank Centre in London is filled with the sounds of the sitar, sarod and tabla. At South Asian Sounds, a festival that reaches its climax on Sunday, some of the region's finest musicians take centre stage. The programme spans several genres, from Indian classical music and folk song to experimental jazz.

London is a fitting location for such a celebration: around 20% of the city's residents have South Asian heritage. Yet the festival also points to a growing global audience for the region's music. Last year Diljit Dosanjh became the first Indian artist to perform at Coachella, an American music festival. In 2022 "Pasoori", a song by Ali Sethi, a Pakistani-American musician, and Shae Gill, a Pakistani singer, became the most-searched track in the world after it featured in "Ms Marvel", a TV show. Western artists still dominate the global music industry. But South Asians are finding a place on the playlist.

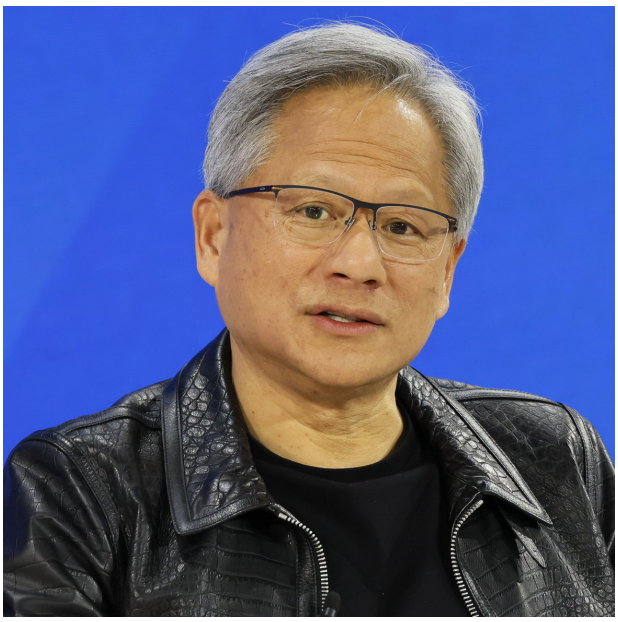


Photo: Getty Images

Jensen Huang, shovel-maker for the AI gold rush

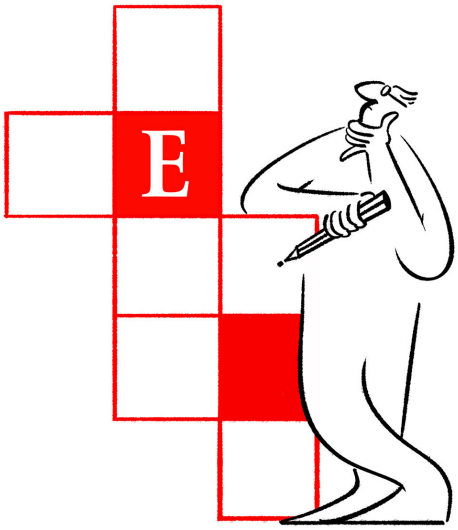
Jensen Huang is a paranoid man. The boss of Nvidia, an American chip designer, is fond of saying that his company is always “30 days away from going out of business”. Recent developments, however, are making a mockery of such talk. Thanks to an artificial-intelligence (AI) boom, Nvidia is now America’s third-most valuable firm. Its market capitalisation of $2.2trn is only exceeded by Microsoft and Apple.

Mr Huang’s paranoia can be traced back to his roots. After his family moved from Taiwan to America he was sent to a Baptist school for troubled youths. There, he shared a room with a knife-scarred boy. That did little to distract him from academic success: he sped through high school, graduating at 16. In 1993, aged 30 and armed with two degrees in electrical engineering, he founded Nvidia with two other engineers. The start-up had to compete in a cut-throat semiconductor market dominated by heavyweights like Intel, then the world’s biggest chipmaker.

Beyond paranoia, two further traits explain how Mr Huang has propelled Nvidia to success. The first is a focus on the long term.

He realised early on that simply making fast chips was not enough: customers also needed help in tailoring them for their specific needs. In the mid 2000s he started investing in “CUDA”, a software platform that enables Nvidia’s customers to make the most of its chips. Many saw software development as a costly distraction for a chip company. But today CUDA is one of the company’s strongest defences against competitors.

The second is Mr Huang’s propensity for bold bets. Almost a decade ago he realised that Nvidia’s graphics-processor units, which were originally built for video-game consoles, also worked well for training AI models. Mr Huang shifted his company’s resources towards building chips for AI applications, long before the current boom in large language models. In 2017 he surprised investors by saying that the company’s transition to AI could “work out great, or terribly” since the firm was “all in”. Even for Mr Huang, great would be an understatement.



Weekly crossword

Our crossword has two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give

the same answers, all of which feature in articles in this week's edition of *The Economist*:

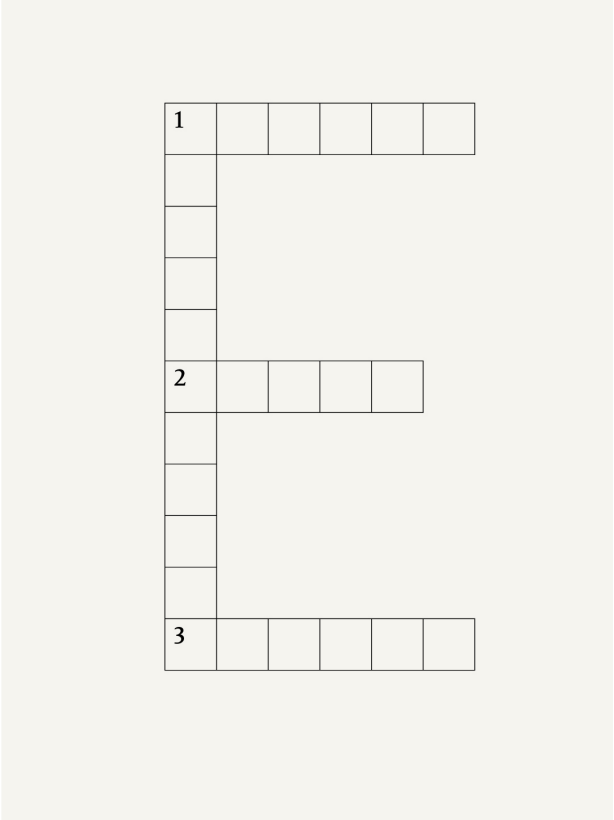
Cryptic clues

1 *down* Contraceptives press for formal approval (6,5)
1 *across* Anger a twisted old leader (6)
2 *across* Where roads come from, so we are told (5)
3 *across* Swap an amazing selection of headwear (6)

Factual clues

1 *down* Common description of China's parliament (6,5)
1 *across* American president who blocked arms sales to Israel (6)
2 *across* What Brothers of Italy has in post-fascist movements (5)
3 *across* Country where the president has been investigated for corruption (6)

Email all four answers, along with your home city and country, by 9am GMT on Monday to . We will pick randomly from those with the right answers and crown three winners in next week's edition.



The winners of this week’s quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week’s quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Victor Arotsky, London, Britain
Josh Perrott, Toronto, Canada

Alexandra Balan, Bucharest, Romania

They all gave the correct answers of *Shake Shack*, *the blank tile*, *extract blood*, *cardigan* and *Love Story.* The theme is hits by Taylor Swift: *Shake It Off*, *Blank Space*, *Bad Blood*, *Cardigan* and *Love Story*.

The questions were:

Monday: Which burger chain was founded in New York in 2004 by Danny Meyer?
Tuesday: Which is the only tile in Scrabble that scores zero points?
Wednesday: What role does a phlebotomist play in medicine?
Thursday: What is the term for a knitted jumper that buttons up?
Friday: Which 1970 movie saw Ryan O'Neal romance Ali McGraw?

The vote is a power, a weapon of offence and defence, a prayer.

Carrie Chapman Catt